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Seating Upgrade

Saturday's dinner was excellent. I pushed aside my regret over what had happened the previous night. It was over and done, and I refused to let it overshadow our second attempt. I also refused to give in to the concerns that were still in the back of my mind. I stayed in the present, and simply enjoyed myself. The result was so good, we made it a weekly habit. Not only was it fun, but it gave our relationship a feel that was familiar to us.

For the first time, it felt like Danni and I were officially dating.

Things got even more familiar when the realities of life began to interfere with the new routine. For example, when the next league event had us shipping off to Australia again. The interruption bothered me. The normalcy had started to take root, and I wasn't going to be satisfied with putting the relationship on pause while we were away. I wanted it to be active. Which is why I had a little something in mind for Danni during the journey.

But, first, I had a little surprise planned for everybody.

The confusion started when I told the women of the FAC division they needed to pack a separate overnight bag for their upcoming event in Brisbane. It got a little worse when I told them we would be gathering at the RSI facility instead of driving separately to the airport, and it got a lot worse when I told them we'd be leaving nearly a full day earlier than usual.

But it really hit its peak when the bus I'd rented rolled up onto the Garden State Parkway in a direction no one expected.

It was Shelby Chesnes who spoke up first.

"Why are we going south?" she asked.

"Because that's the way I told the driver to go."

"Are we making a stop somewhere?"

"Something like that."

"Why can't you just tell us what the hell is happening?" Olivia snapped.

"Why can't you just shut up and enjoy the ride? It won't take long."

For obvious reasons, Danni was the first to get an inkling of where we were headed, and her suspicions were confirmed when the bus started following signs for Monmouth Executive Airport.

"What did you do?" she asked.

I smiled but gave no answer.

The bus dropped us right in front of the small terminal. Isabel was waiting for us when we walked in, and our baggage was gathered almost immediately. IDs were collected. Forms were checked off. Within just a few minutes, the group was standing out in the boarding area.

The scene was almost exactly the same as it had been months ago. The propeller planes were to the right, while the steady din of an idling engine radiated from the line of jets on the left. The only noticeable difference was the positioning of the larger Boeing at the end. It was nearly a quarter mile further out than it had been, and it was now turned nose on to the pickup area.

Realizing that both the distance and the positioning were intentional, I looked at Isa and smiled.

"I like your style, Ortega," I said.

"I thought a grand unveiling would be in order," she smiled back.

Neither of us offered a word of explanation to the others, most of whom weren't paying attention, anyway. But I could see Danni staring at me out of the corner of her eye, and Emma seemed especially tuned in as she drifted our way.

The dull hum escalated into a moderate roar, and the women of RSI turned their collective attention to the line of Lears.

But it was the Boeing that started to move.

"Here she comes, now," Isa said.

Jaws dropped as scattered mumblings and exclamations started to emanate from the group as the plane closed the distance. Then the commotion got louder as Captain Moore wheeled the plane left and the full profile came into view.

"I'll be damned," Danni said from beside me.

In a process that had not been cheap, the jet had been flown down to Alabama, completely sanded down and repainted. The base color was still white, but stylish new details had been added all over the place. The tail was now red with swooping black stripes near the bottom. The underbelly was also red, and the coloring wrapped around to the side of the plane. It ended in waves that rose and fell beneath the windows, highlighted with the same style of striping as the tail. Above the windows, the words *RAMPAGE SPORTS, INC.* were stenciled in large block letters. The letters had been colored with a gradient effect, transitioning diagonally from red in the bottom-left corner of the R to black in the upper-right corner of the C.

I glanced over at Isabel, who was watching intently for my reaction.

"Worth the money?" she asked.

"No," I said with a wry smile, "but it looks damn good."

"It looks GREAT!" Dove corrected.

A chorus of excited murmurs seemed to agree with the statement.

"OK," I smiled at Isa, "it looks great."

"Only the best for my most important client," she said.

Her ear-to-ear smile left no doubt that she was happy, and she had good reason to be.

The plane rolled to a stop, and the group crowded forward, eager to get a look at the interior. Isa stepped to the front so she could board first and give them the tour.

Emma hung back with Danni and I.

"It's like we're legit, now," she said.

I looked at her sideways.

"We weren't legit before?"

"Well, yeah," she said. Then she gestured toward the plane with a sweeping flourish and added, "but this is like *legit* legit."

"Ah," I nodded.

"How can you afford this?" Danni asked.

"I'm taking it out of Emma's salary."

"Very funny," the young actress said.

"No, seriously," Danni prompted.

I shrugged.

"Turns out, it's not really that expensive," I said. "We worked it out that I would lay out a significant chunk to help Isa afford the plane, and she returned the favor by giving us a deal on the monthly rate. With the amount of flying we do, it's going to work out cheaper, in the long run."

They both looked at me.

"Let me get this straight," Emma said. "You have a friend who runs a private airline, and it turns out it's cheaper than flying commercial?"

"Well, I think circumstances had a lot to do with the price."

"Circumstances you didn't know about," Danni said, "because you never bothered to ask."

"Why would I ask her if she had a spare plane just lying around?"

"So, instead," Emma resumed, "we spend years flying to places like Australia in an oversized tin can, when we could have been traveling in style."

I looked back and forth between them for a moment.

"I buy you people a fucking plane, and you're giving me shit about it?"

Emma shrugged.

"What can I say? I can only do what I know how to do."

"Get on the damn plane," I muttered.

The joking stopped and their eyes went wide once we got on board because the remodel hadn't been limited to the exterior.

When Isa had given me the initial tour, what I saw was a configuration meant for capacity. With seats that were a step above commercial, it was basically a people hauler, with room for a hundred or more. Since RSI had a roster of less than forty fighters - who rarely traveled all at the same time - it was capacity we didn't need. So, all that was gone now. Replaced with large, plush leather swivel seats and long curving benches. Tables were scattered throughout. Some small, with room for only two or three. A couple were larger and could comfortably seat seven or eight. The walls and bulkheads were done in tasteful shades of grey. The cabin was brightly lit by sources expertly hidden in the decor. Faint blue trim lighting curved and swooped along the ceiling and ran along the edges of the seats and tables, completing a sleek and modern look. Televisions were positioned here and there, leaving no seat without a view.

"Oh, baby... I got dibs on the remote!" I heard Zendaya say.

"You touch that controller, you lose a limb, rookie," Aly Michalka replied.

"Don't let the idea of riding in style go to your head, ladies," I said. "I expect the same hard work and dedication you gave me before. No, scratch that. I expect it doubled. Because wins equal money, and I need to pay for this thing, somehow."

They replied with a mixture of laughter and playful grousing.

"Don't give me a hard time," I warned. "Remember that flying private means no passenger manifest. I could have one of you dropped out over the ocean, and no one would even know where to look for you."

Moore leaned out of the cockpit.

"Uhm, that's not really..."

"Honestly," I snapped at him. "Why can't you just fly the plane?"

He looked at me, blinked twice, and said, "I'm having second thoughts about this whole thing."

"Yeah, well this is what's keeping us in business," Isa said to him. "So, shut up, and do what the woman says."

Danni and I shared a look.

"That'd look real good on a T-shirt," I said.

"I'd buy one," she replied.

We turned, and I led Danni toward the rear of the plane. As we reached the back of the group, she reached for an empty seat.

"Unh-uh," I said. Then I nodded toward a door at the back of the cabin and added, "We sit back here."

She followed me through into the section I'd reserved as my private office. As soon as we went through, there were two chairs. Then a table - a bit larger than the smaller option available up front - and another chair behind. The same configuration as my office back at RSI, squished into a much smaller space. The colors and lighting matched the main cabin, with a TV mounted on the wall to the left.

Neither of us said anything for a few moments while we both looked around for the first time. Then Danni spoke up.

"It's nice," she said. "The whole plane is beautiful, but... we can't hide back here."

The stable leader, gently putting her foot down. Wanting to be up front, with her troops.

I expected nothing less, but gave her a hard time over it, anyway.

"First of all, yes we can," I said. "I paid a lot of money for this, and I can do whatever I want."

She gave me a long, sideways glance. Waiting for me to drop the high and mighty act, which I've never been able to pull off well anyway.

"Second," I continued, "I don't intend to hide. I was just showing off."

"Well," she said with a smile, "then color me impressed."

We turned around to go back... just in time for me to witness a peanut fly from where Dove was seated toward the general vicinity of Liv and Daya across the aisle. It bounced off the couch between them, then fell to the floor.

I slowly brought my eyes around and stared at the offending legume. Eventually, Liv got the message and picked it up off the floor. Then I slowly and deliberately turned my gaze on Dove. After a brief pause, she put the remaining peanuts away without a word.

High and mighty I can't do, but scary and intimidating? No problem.

* * *

While our new mode of transportation was a huge hit with all involved, the event itself was not our greatest. Not terrible, but nothing to write home about. On the plus side, our only title defense was a successful one, as Emma held off the hard-charging Victoria Justice. On the negative, Aly's never-ending quest for the division title was stymied once again by nemesis Erin Heatherton. And on the pain-in-my-ass front, the rookie trio didn't look much better than last time. Dove gave a passable performance in a ho-hum victory over Sarah Hyland, while Liv and Daya were both dispatched in short order by largely inexperienced opponents. I was convinced we were on the right track by letting Tiz take the three of them under her wing, but it obviously wasn't enough.

Unfortunately, the league calendar marches forward without regard to our problems. That meant Ashley and the other more experienced members of RSI would now be turning their attention to the *Team Warfare* event, leaving the three younger fighters on their own for the next few months.

There was an upside, though. *Team* preparation meant Danni would be spending her days training with all of the best fighters RSI had on the roster. So, those same women who'd been tormenting me for months were going to get the chance to do the same to their stable leader.

Turns out, it was an opportunity they'd all been waiting for. And I made them wait just a little bit longer.

Though the new team plane was modern and comfortable, it had one major drawback: it didn't have anywhere near the range of a commercial airliner. Also, there were regulations governing how long a pilot could be at the controls without rest, and Isa's operation wasn't big enough to have a second crew available. That meant, for longer flights, we needed to make an extra overnight stop. But the plush surrounds and the big screen TV were enough to keep the natives from complaining, and the situation gave me an opportunity I wouldn't have had otherwise. On the return trip, I sent everyone else on without us while Danni and I spent a couple of days in Vancouver, with nothing specific to do. Hiking the Vancouver Seawall, dining on the English Bay and a lot of time spent just strolling around the city... it felt

like we had snuck away while no one was looking and went off and did whatever came to mind. Every second seemed to be planned only the second before, yet everything worked out just right.

Best of all, I felt not an ounce of pressure. I was where I wanted to be with the person I wanted to be with, and nothing else seemed to matter.

No doubt about it. Something strange was happening to me.